FOREIGN OFFICE,

S.W. 1.

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PERSONAL & CONFIDENTIAL:

10th April, 1953.

(FJ. 10310/4)

23

Thank you for your letter of the 8th April about the "Daily Express" enquiry about the Yoshida letter. I should tell you at once that this is a very tricky and difficult subject which has been causing us difficulty over here.

About two months ago Ian Colvin of the "Sunday Express" tried to find out from us exactly when the Foreign Office first knew about the Yoshida letter and when the Secretary of State was first told about it and given a copy. The purpose of the Beaverbrook press in, of course, to attempt to demonstrate that the Secretary of State and the Foreign Office were either weak or else were hoodwinked by the Americans over Far Eastern policy, that we knew about the Yoshida letter before its publication but were unable to impress our views either on the Americans or on the Japanese. We have been very careful in answering questions to go no further than the Secretary of State did in replying to Parliamentary Questions by Mr. Fenner Brockway and others on the 30th January, 1952 (see Hansard for that date, columns 165-168. The "Sunday Express" subsequently published an article on this subject of which I will try to let you have a copy, though I cannot obtain one in time for this bag.

Please ensure that you and others in the Embassy go no further than the Secretary of State's reply in the House of Commons if you are questioned on this subject. It appears from paragraph 2 of your letter that your reply to the "Daily Express" enquiry certainly did not go beyond what the Secretary of State said.

For your own personal information, I attach a copy of a memorandum drawn up recently in the Foreign Office recording the evidence so far as it is available to us about American actions in telling the Embassy and the Secretary of State of the Yoshida letter during the Secretary of State's visit to Washington in January, 1952. This memorandum is purely for your personal information and no use should be made of it in answering press enquiries.

(R.H. Scott)

F.S. Tomlinson, Esq.,

British Embassy,

WASHINGTON.

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20

269
K.C.

FJ.10310/4 (A)

Enclosure with Mr. Hesmondhalgh's minute of 25th March.

SECRET

UNMARKED

The Yoshida Letter

On the 9th January, 1952, when the Secretary of State was in Washington, Mr. Dulles gave Sir O. Franks a copy of a memorandum which had been prepared by the State Department for Mr. Dulles' use. It dealt with the history of the exchanges between U.K., U.S.A. and Japan on the subject of Japanese recognition of China. Paragraph 15 on page 7 of the memorandum reads: "On January 7th, Mr. Dulles received, by pouch, a letter from Mr. Yoshida dated December 24th, 1951, stating Japan's intentions as regards China."

FJ 10310/20 FLAG A

2. The memorandum was given to Sir O. Franks by Mr. Dulles (presumably in the State Department) on the afternoon of the 9th January. It was given by the Ambassador to the Private Secretaries on the evening of the 9th January when the Ambassador returned to the Embassy. As far as is known, it was not seen by the Secretary of State until early on the morning of the 10th January shortly before the meeting held that morning to discuss Japanese relations with China. Notes on the memorandum were prepared in the Embassy immediately before this meeting but there was no time to discuss them with the Secretary of State except on the way down to the State Department in the car.

Mr. Tomlinson's letter to Mr. C.P. Scott FJ 10310/43 FLAG B

3. On the morning of the 10th January, at the same time that last minute efforts were being made to examine Mr. Dulles' memorandum, Sir O. Franks was summoned down to the State Department by Mr. Dulles and was informed of the Yoshida letter. It is not clear from the evidence available whether Sir O. Franks was given a copy of the letter to read or whether Mr. Dulles merely told him about it orally. Two weeks later, in London, (on 27th January), the U.S. Ambassador, in an interview with the Secretary of State, said that Mr. Dulles had shown the Yoshida letter to Sir O. Franks. No copy of the letter was given to Sir O. Franks. What does seem clear is that either the letter was shown to Sir O. Franks in such a fashion that he had no real opportunity to grasp its significance, or that he failed to do so.

Sir W. Strang's minute of 29 Jan on FJ 10310/44 FLAG C

4. Sir O. Franks went straight from his interview with Mr. Dulles to the meeting between the Secretary of State, Mr. Acheson, Mr. Dulles, himself and others on Japan's relations with China. Sir O. Franks had no opportunity to talk to the Secretary of State before the meeting about the interview which he had just had with Mr. Dulles.

S/S's marginal note in red ink on Mr. R.H. Scott's minute of 26 Jan on FJ 10310/44. FLAG D

S/S's marginal note in red ink on Mr. Strang's Shuckburgh's minute of 30 Jan on FJ 10310/44 FLAG E

Mr. Tomlinson's letter of 21st Jan to Shuckburgh, enclosing record of meeting on FJ 10310/44 FLAG F

5. The letter was apparently mentioned at the meeting, though the evidence on this point is not clear. The Secretary of State's recollection was that the letter was not mentioned (though he agrees that he knew of the existence of a letter because Sir O. Franks had told him that Mr. Dulles had just spoken to him about it). According to the recollection of Mr. Tomlinson, who compiled a record of the meeting from memory a week after it had taken place, Mr. Dulles "referred to the fact that he had now received a communication from the Japanese Prime

/Minister

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Minister stating the intentions of the Japanese Government and that it would probably be necessary to make use of this during the Senate's consideration of the Peace Treaty with Japan." On the other hand, the telegram which the Secretary of State sent reporting on the meeting immediately after it had taken place does not mention the letter.

6. From all this, the following emerges:

(i) The letter was only shown (if indeed it ever was shown) to Sir O. Franks in a hurried fashion just before the meeting on the morning of the 10th January.

(ii) No copy was given to a British official at the time the Secretary of State was in Washington.

(iii) It was mentioned, if at all, only in a perfunctory fashion at the meeting on the morning of the 10th January.

(iv) Nothing was said about publishing it in the near future.

7. Early on the morning of the 16th January, Mr. Shima of the Japanese Ministry of Foreign Affairs, gave Mr. Clutton, in Tokyo, a copy of the Yoshida letter saying that it would be published at 10 o'clock Japanese time that morning. An emergency telegram was sent to the Foreign Office which arrived after the time of publication.

8. Mr. Acheson subsequently apologised to the Secretary of State for the manner of publication.

FLAG G
W'Ton tel No 107 to F.O. of 10 Jan - FJ 10310/4

FLAG H
Tokyo tel. No 70 of 16 Jan - FJ 10310/6

FLAG I.
W'Ton tel No 186 of 16 Jan - FJ 10310/10

FMMasters

26th March, 1953

This is the sequence of events, but I suggest that our recommendation (clause (a)) to give no further assistance to the Sunday Express stands.

R.H. Scott
26/3

Permanent Under Secretary.

I agree.

W. Strang
26/3

News Dept. Hold Soon

FMM 31/3

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